Not important, she said with a laugh. The point was, she was going with three girlfriends to Spain, and then with two girlfriends to Italy, and then—

She looked at her calendar. I looked at mine.

She raised her eyes, smiled.

What is it? Tell me.

Actually, there's one small window…

Recently, she explained, a castmate had advised her not to be so structured about her summer of eating, praying and loving. Keep one week open, this castmate said, leave room for magic, so she'd been saying no to all kinds of things, reserving one week, even turning down a very dreamy bike trip through the lavender fields of southern France…

I looked at my calendar and said: *I have one week open as well.*

What if they're the same week?

What if?

Is it possible?

How crazy would that be?

It was the same week.

I suggested we spend it in Botswana. I gave her my best Botswana pitch. Birthplace of all humankind. Most sparsely populated nation on earth. True garden of Eden, with 40 percent of the land given over to Nature.

Plus, the largest number of elephants of any nation on earth.

Above all, it was the place where I'd found myself, where I always re-found myself, where I always felt close to—magic? If she was interested in magic, she should come with me, experience it with me. Camp under the stars, in the middle of nowhere, which is actually Everywhere.

She stared.

I realize it's crazy, I said. *But all of this is obviously crazy*.

6.

WE COULDN'T FLY TOGETHER. For one thing, I was already going to be in Africa. I was scheduled to be in Malawi, doing conservation work with